opposition to continued European domination: in 1919, British and French mandates were imposed on the Arab countries of Iraq, Syria, Lebanon, Transjordan and Palestine (see page 8).

Above all, however, Arab nationalism emerged as a growing political movement in the 1930s and the main reason was the increasing Jewish immigration to Palestine. Opposition to Zionism was the one issue on which all the Arabs of the Middle East could agree. The events in Palestine, especially the Arab Rebellion from 1936 (see page 13), contributed to the growth of national feeling among Arab people.

Although most Arabs still felt that their first loyalty was to their tribe, clan or region, there was growing support for a single Arab state, especially among the urban, educated classes in countries such as Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon and Iraq, as well as Palestine. Nevertheless, it was separate Arab states that emerged in the twentieth century and most of their governments did not wish to merge and form a single Arab state. They did, however, show their solidarity when their leaders met in a conference in Cairo in 1945 and formed the Arab League. Then, a few years later, the emergence of the state of Israel and the humiliating defeat of the invading Arab armies united the Arabs in their hatred of the new Jewish state. The Arabs also resented the Western powers, especially Britain and the USA, whom they blamed for the creation of the state of Israel in the first place.

Key date
Formation of Arab League: 1945

Nasser and the West

Key question
Why did Nasser view the West as a threat?

In Egypt, as we have seen (pages 37–9), it was the war against Israel in 1948–9 that acted as the catalyst that led the army to overthrow the monarchy. Nasser and his fellow army officers had been so appalled by the incompetence of the Egyptian government in the 1948–9 war that they started plotting to take over the government soon afterwards. They overthrew the King's government in 1952. Next, in order to establish complete independence for Egypt, they had to get rid of the British troops who were stationed on the Suez Canal. This they achieved peacefully, by agreement with the British government, in 1954. However, it was also agreed that British officials would continue to operate the Canal and this therefore remained as a symbol of Western domination.

In the 1950s, the British and the Americans tried to persuade Nasser's government to join an anti-Soviet alliance. This was the era of the **Cold War** and the Western powers wished to contain the spread of Soviet power and influence. When the Americans explained to Nasser what a threat Soviet Russia was, he pointed out that it was '5000 miles away'. For him, it was the Western powers and Israel that posed the greater threat to Egypt's stability and independence. Nasser wished to stay independent of any pro-Western alliance. This neutral stand made the Western powers suspicious because they saw things through Cold War eyes: if Egypt was not *for* them, they suspected it must be against them.

Key term
Cold War
A state of tension, but not actual war, that existed between the USA and the Soviet Union between the late 1940s and late 1980s.